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lens-style cameras that can be attached to smartphones.

Zeiss supports Sony throughout the optical design and development process. It then tests and approves prototypes. It also develops 25 of its own distinctive lenses that perfectly fit Sony cameras. This is how symbiotic this partnership is, and an extremely successful one too. They celebrated 20 years of this partnership in 2015, and are still going strong. They have sold more than 185 million products through this collaboration, which continues even today.

Looking forward. Zeiss, in the meantime, is not depending much on Nokia and Sony. It has the following four focus areas:

1. Semiconductor manufacturing technology that is enabling the manufacture of powerful microchips
2. Medical technology, like products and solutions for ophthalmology, neurosurgery, ENT surgery, dentistry and oncology
3. Precision equipment and microscope systems to ensure even the tiniest structures and processes become visible
4. Eyeglass lenses for movie and camera lenses, binoculars, etc

Zeiss is not only exploiting its core strength of lenses but, has taken that expertise into other industries as well.

Takeaway. From its inception, Zeiss has kept pace with the market, understood its consumers and been an innovator. It has had many firsts over the years. It has partnered with other camera companies like Hasselblad and Sony, which ensured a consistent delivery of quality lenses.

Building a brand early on, and consistently, is critical to the longevity of a business. Zeiss ensured that it survived when its competitors failed and positioned itself perfectly to be the ingredient brand in one of the biggest booms of camera phones.

The bottom line

A few key principles that can be taken away from these cases are:

1. Speaking to a niche audience that is knowledgeable and impatient has advantages for a company; it is pushed to the limit when it comes to innovation. The desire to surprise its consumers can be a great motivator for a company.

2. Partnering is a critical step to stay at the cutting edge. Zeiss did it for the longest and so did NVIDIA. Their partnerships include licensing, sharing of knowledge, technology and know-how.

3. Building a brand is critical with the end-user. This creates pull for the brand, and big players like Xbox, PlayStation and Nokia rely on the brand to build their expertise and loyalty with their customers. It allows them to charge a premium with the end-user partly. This is a great position to be in for any company.

I hope this article inspires Indian ingredient brands for Indian and global markets—principles are quite the same wherever you may be. As long as you invest in development and choose your segment wisely, there are opportunities out there waiting to be either created or grabbed. **EFY**